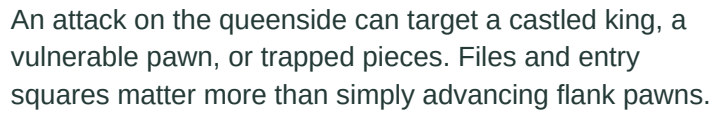


Queenside attacks

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES



Locate the critical target and which pawn or piece move opens a route toward it. Check whether central counterplay interrupts the plan.

The defending king is on b1. Absolute pin: pawn on b2.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

16...Nc3+ Check restricts White to 2 legal replies here. From c3 it attacks king on b1 and rook on d1. Recorded reply:
17.Ka1.

18...Nxd1 The knight captures the rook on d1.

At the end, nominal material is White 18 / Black 22 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, Black's balance changes by +5. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

Using $P=1$, $N/B=3$, $R=5$, $Q=9$, how much does Black's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer:** +5: the balance goes from -1 to +4. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

The board's left half is not inherently safe. Queen checks and rook entries can make a queenside king as vulnerable as a kingside one.